

Doing Indigenous Epistemology

Internal Debates about Inside Knowledge in Māori Society

by Toon van Meijl

Indigenous peoples around the world are exploring indigenous epistemology with the aim to reassert the validity of their own ways of knowing and being. This assertion is taking place not only among indigenous scholars in the academy but it is also happening among people with little or no schooling. In this context, indigenous people often think of themselves as having “inside knowledge” or being “inside knowledge.” This raises the question whether being inside knowledge is a comprehensive frame forming subjectivity or whether indigenous actors are also active agents in the process of producing knowledge. In search for an answer to this question, I analyze an internal debate in a Māori community about the spiritual quality of water, which some Māori leaders were reconstructing in their struggle against an extension of water rights to a coal mining corporation. Following the ethnographic analysis, a plural conception of knowledge is proposed to allow for different ways of knowing.

One of the more positive aspects of our existence in Oceania is that truth is flexible and negotiable, despite attempts by some of us to impose political, religious, and other forms of absolutism. Versions of truth may be accepted for particular purposes and moments, only to be reversed when circumstances demand other versions; and we often accede to things just to stop being bombarded, and then go ahead and do what we want to do anyway. (Hau'ofa 2000:454)

This paper reflects on the widespread claim that indigenous knowledge and epistemology are radically different from Western science and scholarship (Gegeo 2001; Gillett 2009; Huffer and Qalo 2004; Māhina 2010; Roberts and Wills 1998; Smith 2012 [1999]; Subramani 2001; Tau 2001). The recent emergence of this discourse in indigenous societies is intertwined with the increasing integration of the world economy, which induces a process of counter globalization made up of a series of responses that are all revamping the local in light of the global (Appadurai 1995; Friedman and Ekholm Friedman 2013; Merlan 2009). These include a re-valuation of indigenous knowledge in societies that perceive their distinct way of life as under threat. Let me unpack this context in some more detail before moving on to the epistemological debate about differences in knowledge and the validation of knowledge.

My ethnographic focus is on the Pacific, where the wish to counter the negative impact of globalization is entangled with

hard feelings about the legacy of colonialism and the associated difficulties to achieve comprehensive independence in the wake of the decolonization process. Against this background, a re-valuation of indigenous values, customs, and traditions has taken place in recent decades (Babadzan 2009; Hermann 2011; Hviding and Rio 2011). In local societies, traditional customs and traditions have been reassessed and revived with great passion, leading to popular discourses about *kastom* in Melanesia and local customs in Micronesian and Polynesian societies, for example, *anga fakatonga* in Tonga and *Māoritanga* in New Zealand.

The renaissance of cultural traditions resulted, in turn, in representations of culture as a resource that can be claimed as “property” of which the claimants are the “intellectual owners” (van Meijl 2009b). This discourse of cultural property emerged also partly in response to globalization, since cultural traditions are increasingly disseminated around the world following innovations in information and communication technologies. This globalization of local traditions provokes the desire to control “culture,” which is particularly widespread in societies who fear that the survival of their cultural heritage is at risk (Brown 2003).

In this context, indigenous knowledge is also being revaluated, and a debate has emerged about the value and validity of indigenous knowledge and indigenous epistemologies as opposed to the epistemological conceptions of knowledge and their associated presuppositions that became dominant in the Pacific during the colonial era (e.g., Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo 2001, 2002; Huffer and Qalo 2004; Smith 2012 [1999]). Although the discourse about indigenous epistemology is partly linked to the discussion about the ownership of cultural heritage, its aim is not primarily to protect indigenous knowledge. Rather it is premised on the assumption that knowledge is in-

Toon van Meijl is Professor and Chair of Cultural Anthropology in the Department of Anthropology and Development Studies at Radboud University (PO Box 9104, 6500 HE Nijmegen, The Netherlands [t.vanmeijl@ru.nl]). This paper was submitted 23 VII 16, accepted 27 IV 17, and electronically published 20 II 19.

trinsically linked to power and that, as David Gegeo and Ann Watson-Gegeo (2001:55) phrased it, the process of decolonization in the Pacific can only be completed by the dehegemonization of philosophical theories of knowledge in the Pacific. From this statement it can be inferred that the discourse of indigenous epistemologies aims principally at reconstructing and revaluing indigenous conceptions of knowledge, which are assumed to be radically different from scientific perspectives on knowledge that are dominating Western academies.

A major source of inspiration in the early resistance against the hegemony of colonial knowledge has been Epeli Hau'ofa's effort to deconstruct the discourse that reminds Islanders constantly of their smallness, isolation, limited resources, and dependency and the fragmented nature of their cultures. Against the myths and metaphors of smallness and dependency, Hau'ofa advanced an enlarged vision of Oceania:

Oceania is vast, Oceania is expanding, Oceania is hospitable and generous, Oceania is humanity rising from the depths of brine and regions of fire deeper still, Oceania is us. We are the sea, we are the ocean, we must wake up to this ancient truth and together use it to overturn all hegemonic views that aim ultimately to confine us again, physically and psychologically, in the tiny spaces which we have resisted accepting as our sole appointed place, and from which we have recently liberated ourselves. We must not allow anyone to belittle us again, and take away our freedom. (Hau'ofa 1993:16)

Several scholars have been instrumental in the interpretation of the connection between culture and power in this grand vision of Oceania. Vilsoni Hereniko (2000), following Edward Said, linked the usurpation of oral traditions and other indigenous sources of knowledge to the imperial imperative to block indigenous narratives from forming or emerging. The methodological implications of the link between culture and imperialism were addressed by the Māori scholar Linda Tuhiwai Smith (2012 [1999]), who questioned whether Western intellectuals can be reliable allies in the resistance to imperialism and argued that peoples who are subjected to research should always be able to control all research that concerns them directly or indirectly. The Hawaiian educationalist Manulani Aluli Meyer (2001, 2003) identified a range of epistemological themes that she considers crucial building blocks of a new understanding of Hawaiian identity and, in a broader sense, Pacific identities. At the same time, Subramani (2001, 2003), an Indo-Fijian professor in literature at the University of the South Pacific, advocated that for the reinscription of Pacific epistemologies to be successful, it would be important to blur the usual disciplinary boundaries, including the divisions of oral speech from written materials and of visual imagery from music and performance. Subsequently, he became an important drive behind a major, interdisciplinary conference on Pacific epistemologies held in Fiji in 2006. The ultimate aim of the quest for indigenous knowledge was formulated unequivocally at this conference: to discard the mantle of colonialism and to

achieve comprehensive independence—or sovereignty in the case of indigenous peoples in the Pacific.

In this paper I would like to elaborate on a point made by Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo (2001, 2002), who have written about the implications of a renewed focus on indigenous epistemology for local development projects in the Solomon Islands. They have specifically identified the goal of retrieving and reclaiming local ways of thinking and knowing as critical for campaigns that seek to provide ammunition to young Pacific Islanders who consider local traditions and cultural customs as obstacles to their personal advancement. After all, many Pacific youngsters strongly support the project of modernization, which is often believed to be incompatible with traditional modes of being and knowing. To counter the impact of modernization and globalization, it is therefore important to substantiate a distinct Pacific identity by reasserting the validity of indigenous ways of knowing and being. Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo (2001:55) argue that this is the only way to resist the hegemony of mainstream epistemology from former imperial powers. And to bring the decolonization process in the Pacific to the level of dehegemonization, it is crucial to identify indigenous epistemic frameworks that may be used to construct and theorize indigenous knowledge. Pursuing indigenous knowledge and epistemology is also regarded as necessary in order to discontinue the exclusive reliance on the production of knowledge by cultural outsiders, who are not naturally connected to Pacific communities in the first place.

At this point, it is necessary to discuss the question of what is understood by epistemology in various ranks and files of the debate and also to clarify my own understanding of knowledge production and epistemology. The philosophical concept of epistemology refers both to the theory of knowledge and to the process of theorizing knowledge, including the nature, sources, frameworks, and limits of knowledge (Lechte 2003:71–73). Epistemology is, in other words, concerned with “who can be a knower, what can be known, what constitutes knowledge, sources of evidence for constructing knowledge, what constitutes truth, how truth is to be verified, how evidence becomes truth, how valid inferences are to be drawn, the role of belief in evidence, and related issues” (Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo 2001:57).

The benchmark of indigenous epistemology is a fundamental distinction between traditional knowledge systems and scientific models of knowledge and associated approaches of epistemology. In indigenous epistemology, “to know” something is to locate it in space and time and to consider it holistically as part of an overarching cosmic order in which individual persons, tribal communities, all other animate and inanimate things, and even knowledge itself are interrelated (Roberts and Wills 1998:45). Māori people, for example, frequently locate themselves relative to an origin within their ancestral homeland by including information about the canoe that brought their ancestors to New Zealand as well as the mountain and river that are characteristic of their tribal region:

Ko Tainui te waka.
Ko Taupiri te maunga.
Ko Waikato te awa.

Tainui is my canoe.
Taupiri is my mountain.
Waikato is my river.

Apart from being able to locate knowledge objects in space and time, an additional feature of indigenous knowledge systems is to have knowledge of their *whakapapa* or genealogies (Roberts 2012, 2013; Roberts et al. 2004). This is also reflected in the tribal saying quoted above: to know oneself is to know about your tribal territory, the mountains, the rivers, trees, rocks, fishes, and the wind and how these are interrelated in and through *whakapapa*. As such, *whakapapa* provide a framework for understanding how everything, animate and inanimate, is connected into a single “family tree” or “taxonomy of the universe” (Roberts and Wills 1998:45). As a consequence, *whakapapa* provide not only the cognitive framework for ordering and classifying the entire phenomenal world but also for developing theories about knowledge. Since *whakapapa* provide a grand scheme for understanding the origin and appearance of the entire universe, knowledge associated with this order requires understandings derived from all sources open to human perception, subjective as well as objective, so that the interrelations of the biological and material order with the social and cultural order can be understood (Roberts and Wills 1998:61–62). Hence, indigenous epistemology is founded on a view of the world in which the unifying ontological principle is *whakapapa* rather than matter.

Although not all indigenous knowledge systems position genealogies at the center, the example of Māori *whakapapa* illustrates the contrast that is drawn between conventional anthropological concepts such as “kinship” or “genealogy” and indigenous modes of relational connections that complicate any type of conceptualization as it invariably implies objectification (Amiria Salmond 2013). In recent years, the question of how indigenous knowledge, for example, about *whakapapa* or genealogies, should be represented in epistemology has also been addressed from an ontological perspective that is highly critical of scientific accounts for difference in terms of culturally diverse ways of knowing and representing reality (Amiria Salmond 2014). Although ontology in Western philosophy was always singular, the so-called ontological turn in anthropology aims at pluralizing reality, a move that is meant to liberate us from the modern Cartesian dualism (Alberti 2016). Ontologists argue that the widespread assumption of a dichotomy between subject versus object excludes the possibility of other types of relations between mind and matter. Influential scholars of the ontological turn, such as Viveiros de Castro (2012) and Descola (2013), have in different ways challenged very basic Western presuppositions by turning upside down beliefs about the relation between culture and nature, replacing our view of a singular nature with multiple cultures by a perspective on multiple natures, or ontological worlds, and a singular culture or way of knowing those worlds.

The notion of multiple ontologies has not immediately resulted in a wealth of anthropological descriptions of alternative ontologies, with the overwhelming ethnography by Eduardo Kohn (2013) standing out as a fine exception. Nonetheless, the ontological turn has generated a fundamental debate about the question of how people communicate across different ontologies (see Kohn 2015). Even though Descola (2013:112–125) acknowledges that the four ontologies that he distinguishes are not mutually exclusive, with humans activating any mode of identification according to circumstances, I am reluctant to share the ontological turn’s assumption that there are different understandings of being (cf. Paleček and Risjord 2013). My qualms about the ontological turn partly proceed from a critical analysis of the assumption of indigenous epistemologies that different types of knowledge are possessed by indigenous peoples and (former) colonists. It is beyond the scope of this paper to include a comprehensive discussion of the ontological debate, more specifically, the question of how Pacific ontologies may differ from Western ontologies. Instead, I will demonstrate, ethnographically and theoretically, that a dichotomy between indigenous epistemologies and so-called scientific perspectives on knowledge is unproductive.

My argument focuses on the distinction between indigenous knowledge and the scientific model of knowledge that was developed during and inherited from the European Enlightenment. This model is based on technological metaphysics in which material constitution and causation by scientifically investigable mechanisms constitute the norm that also governs the dominant regime of truth (Gillett 2009). In this perspective, knowledge is primarily understood in terms of objectivity, and science is supposed to hold the exclusive rights to knowledge production. Although this scientific paradigm of knowledge is dominating Western academies, and increasingly also their faculties of social sciences, it has been complemented by a different perspective on knowledge in the arts and humanities. In those disciplines, including anthropology, knowledge is a highly ambiguous concept because it is interlinked with a focus on meaning that is by definition rather diverse, often personal too, if not subjective. Methodologically, this conception of knowledge therefore requires a hermeneutical, rather than a scientific, approach in order to do justice to a possible variety of interpretations of different signs and symbols. Dilthey, Heidegger, Gadamer, Ricoeur, and Derrida may be considered the main philosophers who have developed and constructed the epistemological foundation of this perspective on knowledge. The upshot of this epistemological debate, however, is that a rather rigorous dichotomy between objectivity and subjectivity in analogy with the distinction between the natural sciences, on the one hand, and the arts and humanities, on the other, has become institutionalized within the modern academy (Birdsall et al. 2009:1–2).

In this paper I aim at avoiding both objectivist connotations of “knowledge” and subjectivist undertones in the concept of “meaning,” without perpetuating the kind of oppositional

thinking that makes it necessary to make a choice between either end of the spectrum (Birdsall et al. 2009:2–3). Alternatively, I make a distinction between, on the one hand, knowledge as a definite and declarative understanding of something that is known and, on the other hand, ways of knowing as a strategy to understanding that is more flexible and fluid in practice (Keck 1998:10). Over the past few years, the formulation “ways of knowing” (Harris 2007) has emerged as a valid alternative to knowledge since it includes both knowledge production and the interpretation of meaning. As a consequence, it offers the opportunity to depart from a plural conception of knowledge that allows for different ways of knowing, although not without a continuous reflection on their assumptions and aspirations (Birdsall et al. 2009:3).

This epistemic point of departure guides me in my goal to explore how indigenous peoples are doing indigenous epistemology. As Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo (2001) pointed out, indigenous peoples around the world are exploring indigenous epistemology with the aim to reassert the validity of their own ways of knowing and being, partly in resistance to the intensifying hegemony of mainstream knowledge from postcolonial powers. This assertion is taking place not only among indigenous scholars in the academy but it is also happening among people with little or no schooling. Many indigenous individuals at the grassroots level are struggling with epistemological questions and the related issues of truth versus ideology. Not only are they discussing, arguing, and recording culture and traditions, but they are also critiquing and examining in a self-reflexive process their own indigenous strategies for creating knowledge and using knowledge for a variety of purposes. This broad interest in indigenous epistemology probably demonstrates that the renewed attention for traditional knowledge is about not only the revitalization of culture but also the reconstruction of a cultural identity in societies that are ethnically diverse.

In this paper I analyze an internal debate in a Māori community about the spiritual quality of water, which some Māori leaders were reconstructing in their struggle against an extension of water rights to a coal mining corporation. The political goal of this campaign clarifies not only the revitalization of spirituality as a form of cultural critique but also the ambiguous role of inside knowledge in indigenous societies facing a foreign majority on their lands.

The Setting

The debate that is the subject of this paper took place on and around a *marae* of special significance in the Waikato region in New Zealand. Māori *marae* are made up of a combination of a courtyard used for ceremonial purposes and community assembly at special occasions, especially funeral wakes, with a complex of communal buildings, including an ancestral meetinghouse, a dining hall, and sanitary facilities (Metge 1976 [1967]:227–245; Anne Salmond 1975:31–90). *Marae* are gen-

erally considered to be the final refuge of Māori where they can continue their distinct way of life on their own terms.

Most *marae* are no longer used as an extension of daily living quarters, but Waahi Pa is one of the very few *marae* in New Zealand on and around which a sizable community is living, in this case made up of approximately 500 people. Waahi Pa is also a special *marae* since it is the home of the “paramount family” (*kāhui ariki*) of the *Kīngitanga* or Māori King Movement. The *Kīngitanga* was set up in 1858 in opposition to the threat of colonial domination (van Meijl 1993). The followers of the Māori King were seen as rebels, however, which also caused the government to confiscate their lands in 1864. This included the entire Waikato region, which contains some of the most fertile lands in New Zealand, lands that were required for colonial settlement. Obviously, these events have marked the history of the *Kīngitanga*, while they continue to characterize the contemporary identity of the Waikato-Tainui. A settlement of the confiscations was not signed until 1995 (McCan 2001). It provided for the return of about 3% of the lands originally confiscated, added to NZD 170 million in financial compensation for the lands that could no longer be returned to Māori ownership (van Meijl 2003, 2013).

The first Māori King, Potatau Te Wherowhero, chief of the Ngāti Mahuta subtribe in the Waikato region, was also living on Waahi Pa. The current head of the *Kīngitanga*, King Tuheitia, the sixth descendant in the genealogy from Potatau, is still residing on the same *marae*. As a consequence, Waahi Pa is a *marae* with a royal status, even though since 1938 the Māori monarchy also has an official residence at Tūrangawaewae in Ngāruawāhia for special functions such as hosting other heads of state. Although the Māori King is not recognized as king of all Māori people, he continues to enjoy a very special status as one of the most distinguished chiefs in New Zealand.

Given the significance of Waahi Pa as home of the *Kīngitanga*, it was, at the very least, rather remarkable that in the mid-1970s the New Zealand government decided to build a huge power station right next to this distinguished *marae*. The construction of an energy plant disturbed the rather peaceful community life at Waahi Pa, as some families as well as the community's school had to be relocated elsewhere in town, while the farm of the royal family was dispossessed. It was also disappointing that, of the 400 jobs that were created, very few were filled by people from the Māori community. Furthermore, the operation of the power station had a disastrous impact on the ecological condition of the Waikato River flowing alongside the *marae* and the Waahi Lake that is directly connected to it. The station's cooling water is drawn from the Waikato River, and when it is discharged back into the river it produces a plume of warmer water, killing all the fish until it cools by mixing with more water 2 km downstream. This affected not only the availability of food resources for the local community but also the traditional prestige of the *marae* that relied on local species of fish as an essential part of the hospitality provided by the royal family at many ceremonial occasions.

The Māori community of Waahi Pa was unable to stop the construction of the power station, but its unceasing resistance resulted in some recognition from the government. Eventually the government acknowledged that it had made a misappraisal of the environmental impact, which it aimed at repairing with a small compensation settlement. In the early 1980s, then, the community of Waahi Pa was enabled to renovate *marae* facilities with the compensation funds, but the relative success of the negotiations with the government also sparked a wider review of political, economic, and cultural aspirations. At Waahi Pa, a new model for community development was designed in which the concept of *marae* was innovated by assigning it new roles in the social and economic development of Māori communities, for example, with regard to preventative health care and bilingual education (van Meijl 1996).

It goes without saying that in these circumstances my role as fieldworker was far from limited to academic research. I had been granted permission to live on this royal *marae* only on the condition that I would contribute to the development process. In practice, I operated as consultant on many development projects and political programs, including the continuous battle with the power station about the water management in the catchment area and the pollution of local waterways by the mining operations that supplied the energy production process with coal. In this context, water was usually classified as a spiritual force, although the spiritual quality of water also generated a debate about traditional knowledge and epistemology in the community. It is this debate on which I would like to reflect below.

Water and Māori Spirituality¹

As already indicated, Waahi Pa is located on the banks of the Waikato River and the Waahi Lake. Until the mid-seventies, the Waahi Lake and the Waahi Stream running from the lake to the Waikato River provided the Māori communities on its shores with an abundance of food, especially eels (*tuna*). The food resources from the waters around the *marae* were particularly important in fulfilling the community's obligations to nourish guests on ceremonial occasions. Several of these foods were special to the area, for example, the *puhi* eel, which is considered a delicacy. At some places people used to catch plenty of whitebait, while in swampy areas they found mudfish, carp, and catfish. Other traditional food resources that the old peo-

ple recall with great fondness catching and collecting include freshwater mussels, mullet, water fowl, and the vegetable many Māori people treasure as a treat, watercress. The *marae* community also used to be attached to Lake Waahi for the purpose of recreation. In the past, the water had been crystal clear, and at the end of the day many families would go swimming in the lake. The spot had simply been ideal—until it all went wrong.

In recent decades, there has been a gradual decline in water clarity that has resulted in significant reductions in the quality and quantity of today's food resources. In 1974 the Huntly West Mine commenced operations and began using groundwater for purposes of mine dewatering and hydromining as well as for bathhouses. The Huntly West Mine discharged back into the lake and its tributaries the mine lodgment water and stormwater runoff from surface mine facilities as well as bathhouse and ablution block sewage. In 1978, only 4 years later, the water in the lake was quite turbid. The wide and diverse range of plants and animals in the lake has been reduced to almost only algae.

It goes without saying that the Waahi community is most upset about the changes in their "food basket." They have never had any say in the management of the lake or the decision making about different forms of pollution entering its waterways. The lake is part of the area that was confiscated in 1864, but it is still considered "our lake." The feeling of ownership of the lake is reinforced by the fact that it is almost inaccessible from the road. Until recently, the shores of the lake could only be reached from the West Mine or via a path from the rear of the *marae*.

Until 1989, Lake Waahi was administered by the Waikato Catchment Board (hereafter, WCB), which was responsible for all water and soil resources in the area.² In 1985 the then Waikato Valley Authority publicly proposed a water and soil management plan for the Lake Waahi Catchment because of the deterioration of the water quality as a result of energy development in the region. Since there was no Māori representation on the WCB, the local Māori people were only entitled to voice their opinions as members of the larger community, which, as laid down by statute, had to be consulted about the management plan. The Waahi community then became involved for the first time in discussions about the management of the lake.

The arguments advanced by the community against the WCB tended to differ according to context. Internally, it was basically a concern for the eels that was expressed. Not infrequently people in the community told me that they were glad I was from "Holland" because they knew that other than Māori people, Dutch people are among the very few who are fond of smoked eels. Hence it was assumed that I would be prepared to support their struggle for the eels, and I was specifically

1. The case study discussed in this paper took place in the late 1980s, but the dispute between the Māori community and the power station about the impact of the energy operations on the environment lingered on until 2010, when at long last a relatively satisfactory compensation package was negotiated. The details of the compensation have never been disclosed in the media and I have been asked not to include them in this paper either. By the same token, the Māori community did not want this case study to be discussed in an academic paper until after a settlement had been signed with the power station.

2. Since late 1989 the Waikato Catchment Board, along with other local councils, boards, and authorities, has been incorporated in the Waikato Regional Council as part of a reorganization scheme of the Local Government Commission.

requested to incorporate a section on the issue in my dissertation. And when people talked about the state of the lake before it was polluted, they spoke almost exclusively of the recreational aspects of the community's attachment to the lake. Occasionally it was mentioned that before 1960 the lake was also used for baptizing.

Externally, however, in the interaction with the water authorities, the spiritual qualities of the water were emphasized over the more mundane usages of the lake. It was argued that the water in the lake was considered highly *tapu* and that it was traditionally used for spiritual cleansing. When people had problems, were ill, or were about to undertake a journey, they would sprinkle themselves with water from the river or the lake. Similarly, water from tribal sources was used for healing purposes, and because of its religious significance it would be disposed of only at special places, such as under the meeting-house, where feet could not trample on it.

In intercultural discourse, the lake was also talked about as an ancestor of the tribe. One of the *taniwha* (demons), a metaphor for chief, of the Waikato tribe was believed to reside in the spiritual realm of the lake, and one of the elders repeatedly mentioned he had seen "Panairaira" walking on the water. For that reason, too, the discharge of polluted water and human waste contributed to a transgression on the sanctity of the lake and a desecration of the spiritual realm of tribal waterways.

In the debate with the water authorities it sometimes seemed as though arguments in regard to Māori spirituality were advanced as part of a political strategy of mystification. Māori people were well aware that spirituality made the many Pākehā (non-Māori, or European) men on the WCB feel extremely uncomfortable, and they clearly attempted to take advantage of it. Their strategy was very effective for a number of reasons. Emphasizing spiritual values invalidated the Pākehā authorities as experts in the field of aquatic life: "We have got to get away from seeing them as experts, because we are the experts. We had our own scientists and they were good scientists because the fish used to flow all the time" (an elder).

In the interaction with the WCB, however, this argument was rarely mentioned, whereas the transgression against spirituality was always highlighted. Thus, the underlying motive regarding the eels was transformed into a mythic motive expressed in terms of concern for the ancestors. The strategic deployment of spiritual values in the debate about water rights moved, as it were, the dynamics of the discussion from a factual to an ideological argument.

In this context, it is noteworthy that local people found it increasingly difficult to advance traditional arguments about the spiritual values of their tribal waters. When preparing submissions to the water authorities the community invariably made use of outside expertise from both Māori allies and Pākehā sympathizers. Regarding a draft of the water and soil management plan for Lake Waahi, for example, a Māori employee of the WCB was roped in to write objections pertaining to the technical aspects of the plan, while I was requested to write about the spiritual aspects of the water.

When I became involved in submission writing, I was given a pile of documents from which I could draw. All reports had been written by sympathizers and accentuated the spiritual qualities of the waters. From a Māori point of view, it was claimed, tribal waters are regarded as *taonga* (treasures) and the people as their *kaitiaki* (guardians). However, few questions I asked about the reports could be answered. The traditional knowledge of the people on the shores of the lake was quite limited in this respect. The only reason for incorporating the old reports again in the new submissions was that they had been written by *tāngata mōhio* (people who know). When contemplating how to approach the water authorities, the elders were generally rather reticent, which was most apparent in the following case.

Water Rights of Coalcorp

Toward the end of 1988, Coal Corporation (Coalcorp) lodged an application for the renewal of its water rights. As part of the procedure, the public was invited to lodge submissions regarding the application. Normally, the community would not be aware of the right to object to applications for water rights, but since 1986 Tama,³ a Māori person from a different tribe, was employed at the WCB, and he had made it part of his job to inform local Māori communities of their rights. One day Tama, who had a bachelor's degree in Māori studies, rang up, and a meeting was arranged. The Māori community was highly motivated to lodge objections to Coalcorp's operations whenever possible, not only because of environmental concerns but also because the mining company had made some 450 people, mainly Māori miners, redundant in Huntly during the mid-1980s when the business had been corporatized following a privatization policy of the government.

Tama explained the ramifications of Coalcorp's application. Since the late 1970s Coalcorp had invested a vast amount of money to build treatment systems and clean the water that had been used for mining purposes before it was discharged back into Lake Waahi. Tama added, however, that scientific treatment of water did not necessarily entail that the procedure was spiritually correct as well. One particular aspect of Coalcorp's water treatment was, according to Tama, unacceptable from a traditional Māori point of view.

Tama expressed his concern about the discharge of treated bathhouse water and sewage back into the lake. He contended that it was not a valid proposition to thwart miners from flushing the toilet or showering after work, but the water lost its *tapu* state when used for those purposes, and, according to him, the treatment of the water was inadequate to regenerate its *tapu* quality. He reminded the locals that in another area a Tainui activist had been arguing consistently that from a Māori point of view only a land-based treatment of human sewage was acceptable. Coalcorp, now, did not treat the "waste" by means of a land-based system. First the water and sewage

3. For ethical reasons, a pseudonym for this person is used in this text.

was processed in a treatment plant. Then it was discharged into two large ponds from where it was drained into a “wetland.” The aquatic plants growing in the wetland were supposed to break down the final components of the sewage before the water flowed back into the lake.

Tama’s specific concerns were twofold. In the first place, he suspected Coalcorp used the term “wetland” deliberately to mislead the Māori community, because they did not know what it was. In a wetland there is a continuous influx of water, but the final section of what Coalcorp referred to as a wetland, was, according to Tama, a swamp. Contrary to a wetland, a swamp indicates an area in which stagnating waters have been infilled with organic matter that is preserved because of an increase in oxygen content over a protracted period of time. In Māori, a swamp was sharply distinguished from a lake and an all-encompassing wetland:

*He repo anō he repo;
he roto anō he roto.*

A swamp is a swamp;
a lake is a lake.

The main reason for this distinction was that in the past canoes and other carvings were sunk in swamps either to dye them or to bury them. Hence, swamps were supposed to be treated with great care and respect, since there was a possibility that certain areas were *tapu* because of the burial of carvings there. Second, Tama expressed concern about the potential effect a wetland could have on the eels. He indicated the chance that in 10 or 20 years a mutation could take place in the biological structure of the aquatic plants, the ability of the aquatic plants to absorb sewage could cease, or they could die so that the sewage would freely flow back into the lake again.

Tama suggested that representatives of the community should phone Coalcorp to request an on-site examination of the water treatment system of the Huntly West Mine and explore the nature of the wetland. Coalcorp proved very amenable to this request, knowing that the WCB was rather sensitive about consultation with Māori communities. Coalcorp organized an excursion for a Māori delegation made up of two elders and Tama, who was formally consulting with the Māori community, and myself. We were shown around by a rather momentous party representing the Coal Corporation, consisting of the technical manager, the water expert, and an environmental consultant, as well as a lawyer taking care of the legal aspects of the application.

On site, the two elders appeared thoroughly impressed with the clarity of the water after it had been treated. They were even offered a glass of treated water to drink. Then they argued that Coalcorp should treat the entire lake in the same way but soon realized that was unfeasible. They deliberated with Tama and asked him whether he thought there was something wrong with the purification of the water. Tama repeated his concerns about the spiritual quality of the water, which, after some elaboration, the elders could understand. They were, however, rather nervous when they had to express their anxiety to the Coal Corporation. In the end, though, they did what was ex-

pected of them: they voiced their concern about Coalcorp’s neglect to “put the *wairua* back in the water.”

After the expedition the issue was discussed within the community. It appeared that nobody really knew what the “official” Māori view should be on the wetland. The elder who acted as spokesperson did not disagree that the water lost its *tapu* quality but could not see how to reinvest the *wairua* into the water other than by pumping it back to Mount Ruapehu where the Waikato River rises.⁴ He was well aware of the impracticable nature of what he thought was the only ideologically pure solution; like most people, he was unacquainted with land-based treatment systems, which he consequently never mentioned as an alternative. By the same token, he did not contemplate closure of the mine supposedly desecrating the water as a feasible alternative either. He described the situation as a catch-22, and for him personally, the only solution was to opt out of the negotiations with Coalcorp.

The main reason the elder resigned from the role of spokesperson was that he did not wish to hold any responsibility for political battles. When the elder had reported back to the community that Coalcorp could only be criticized on spiritual grounds, those most eager to improve the quality of the water in the lake in order to increase the fishing also expressed their hesitations about the effectiveness of such a strategy. They argued that if the water was clean and clear after a treatment of whatever kind, and if the eels were not affected by the treated water, then there were no grounds for lodging objections against Coalcorp’s application. However, they were still advocating further action since they were of the opinion that Coalcorp should be judged not merely on an on-site treatment but on the improvement of the water quality of the lake at large—and nothing indicated that it was improving. From their point of view, the main issue was precisely that: the restoration of the water quality of Lake Waahi.

In the meantime, however, the discussion of the spiritual implications of Coalcorp’s treatment continued. A younger activist contended it was hilarious to pose the question to Coalcorp of how they put the *wairua* back into the water:

Water has always a *wairua*. *Wairua* only means “life,” really. Normally the eels are the *wairua* in the lake, but when you discharge shit in the water, I reckon the shit is the *wairua*. Now, when he [the elderly spokesperson, TvM] is asking Coalcorp how they put the *wairua* back into the water, what he is really asking is how they put the eels back into the water. He should be honest about that.

This view illustrates the prime importance of the fish, something that was endorsed by the more authoritative opinion of another elder who agreed that water is always *tapu*: “Only the shit is ruining it.” Contrary to Tama, these people assumed that water is invariably *tapu*, which implied that the *tapu* or

4. In the discussion about Coalcorp’s water rights, the concepts of *tapu* and *wairua* were used interchangeably.

wairua of water could not be lost even after usage in an ablation block. For that reason, it was not inconsistent that the elder eel activist often proposed to lift the *tapu* of the lake, sell it for an astronomical amount of money, and invest the money in the construction of large ponds in which the community could breed its own eels.

For a solution to the diverging viewpoints on a strategy to object against Coalcorp's application, the community turned to Tama, the educated Māori employee of the WCB. He encouraged the community to continue its struggle for the eels, yet repeated that the transgression and desecration of spiritual values offered the only possibility of grounds for objections. Tama admitted that the community could well be fighting a losing battle, since, for economic reasons, Coalcorp would be granted a renewal of its water rights anyway—"But," he added, "we have to let them know all the time that there are still other people who matter too." To address the spiritual concerns, he proposed to demand the construction of an artificial wetland to protect the natural aquatic plants absorbing the sewage. That the construction of an artificial wetland would have no effect on the quantity or quality of eel catches seemed irrelevant.

In the end, it was decided to proceed with the procedure to object to Coalcorp's application for permission to use local waterways for industrial purposes. Reasons to proceed with the lodging of objections against Coalcorp's application for a renewal of its water rights were compounded by a number of other factors of a purely political nature. Tama and the community officer, whose opinion was highly valued because of his extensive experience with water rights, both argued that it was important to be consistent with other tribal groups within Tainui. They referred to a spokesperson of another Tainui tribe who had gained national recognition as a protector of the environment, among other things, by consistently arguing for land-based treatment systems to reinvest spiritual qualities in sewage effluent. Moreover, the community officer was involved in negotiations with Coalcorp about housing for redundant miners, something that went anything but smoothly and reinforced his zeal to make it far from easy for the Coal Corporation.

When it was finally decided to go ahead with the objections against Coalcorp's application, the elder eel activist who had been designated to speak at the hearing of the Planning Tribunal opted out as well. He told me he could not see what was wrong with the wetland. With his reservations about the argument that Coalcorp's treatment system was spiritually not acceptable, he could not see the point of undertaking intensive preparations for a formal hearing. As a consequence, he attempted to avoid the hearing by putting up the additional condition that he could express the community's objections in the Māori language. This had been made possible by the 1987 Māori Language Act. The act required a request to use the Māori language in legal proceedings to be filed a fortnight in advance so that an interpreter could be arranged. However, when the elder's request to speak in Māori was filed, he still pulled out, with the reason that he refused to participate unless the hearing was held on the *marae*. Clearly, he did everything

possible to avoid further involvement in the case. Eventually, a teacher from Rakaumanga School was nominated to present submissions in the Māori language to the hearing of the Planning Tribunal, a decision that was unprecedented for two reasons. First, the speaker was not of Tainui descent, but he was married to a local woman and had been living in Huntly only for a few years. Second, he was relatively young and had never been considered an elder before.

Three days before my departure from New Zealand, the hearing was held. I was unable to attend the hearing but was informed that the teacher had given a most impressive performance. He had spoken for 2 hours and argued that the people had given the WCB the legal authority to look after the lake "but they had used it as a toilet; therefore: give us the lake back." In addition, he had argued that the *Kingitanga* was set up in the area because there was an abundance of food resources, one of which was the lake: "Give our food basket back." About the wetland he had said: "We used the swamp to treasure our carvings: give our museum back." The locals who were in attendance cried as he talked.

Tama sent me a copy of the tribunal's memorandum about the case, adjourning the hearing until further evidence and submissions on the sewage effluent became available. Effectively, however, it had suspended a renewal of Coalcorp's water rights on the condition that the corporation would design and construct an alternative sewage disposal system that would be more culturally acceptable. In other words, Coalcorp was commanded to build an artificial wetland. It was the first time ever in New Zealand history that an application for water rights was rejected on spiritual grounds, marking a turning point in relationships between local Māori communities and the government regarding freshwater management (Harmsworth, Awatere, and Robb 2016). The decision had only been made possible because Tama had proposed to incorporate in the management plan for Lake Waahi that no human waste sewage should be discharged back into the surface waters of the lake. The Waahi community and Tama celebrated a victory. The overall effect on the quality of the water in the lake and the quantity of the eel catches, however, has been negligible.

What Do We Know about How They Know?

The discussions within the Māori community about its campaign against a renewal of water rights for a coal mining corporation exemplify the ambiguity of knowledge. At the same time, they clarify the strategic objective of debates about epistemology in contemporary indigenous societies. The internal debate about the external presentation of the spiritual quality of water shows that, as Manulani Aluli Meyer (2001:125) pointed out, information is no longer synonymous with knowledge. At the same time, knowledge cannot always be considered the same as knowing. In this section, I will unpack the differences among information, knowledge, and knowing.

Knowledge must be distinguished from knowing since it is not automatically linked with unarticulated lifeways and their

internalization. In the Māori language, these differences are reflected in the distinction between *mātauranga*, which is usually glossed as knowledge, and *mōhiotanga*, which I would like to translate as knowing. Members of the community had access to the knowledge about the spiritual quality of the waters that were dear to them for a variety of reasons. The information was provided by knowledgeable outsiders, such as Tama, but very few people were able to articulate the esoteric knowledge about spirituality because it no longer resonated with their ways of knowing and practicing spirituality in daily life. For that reason, too, they called on outsiders in order to express local objections against the use of water for purposes that intervened with daily practices such as fishing and recreation. In that context, traditional arguments about the spiritual quality of the lake functioned foremost as a metaphor for environmental and political objections against the pollution of the water and the lack of control about what they considered as “their lake.” Hence, too, it is important to point out explicitly that the argument of this paper is not that the spiritual quality of the water was insignificant. Community members never expressed any qualms about the link between spirituality and fish, since in a Māori perspective the absence of eels indicates that the water has been desecrated. Instead, the debate focused on the epistemology of spirituality in the argument that the water was not “alive” and that the *wairua* had been removed from it, which in their view also explained the depletion of fish.

Above I made an analytical distinction between an ideological and a factual dimension of Māori concerns, but here I would like to point out that the ideological dimension was believed to also be factual since many Māori thought that eel numbers had decreased because of polluted spiritual conditions. Since a focus on spirituality was assumed to be more effective in countering external expertise in scientific knowledge, the ideological dimension was highlighted in relation to the water authorities, while internally a concern for the eels dominated. For that reason, too, the question whether Māori discourses about spirituality might be expressions of a so-called animist ontology, which arguably differs fundamentally from a naturalist ontology (see Descola 2013), is inappropriate and unproductive. Clearly, in Māori discourses animist and naturalist ontologies coexisted, but each perspective served different purposes and dominated in different contexts. The strategic focus on spirituality demonstrates that a recognition of Māori ownership, or rather control, of the natural environment prevailed above their concern about fish. On the other hand, this Māori strategy directly followed the information and advice provided by external experts. An internal debate about it also illustrates the distinction between information and knowledge.

The information that was provided by Tama and other *tāngata mōhio*, experts who were consulted to support the community in its struggle against the coal corporation, had to be reconverted into insider’s knowledge so that the local community was able to express its claim on the eels for which they had been fishing from time immemorial. Interestingly, the practical reliance on knowledgeable outsiders is at odds with the

claim by some Māori scholars that “the unifying ontological principle” of Māori epistemology is *whakapapa* or genealogy (Mahuika 1998; Roberts 2012, 2013; Roberts et al. 2004; Tau 2001). Advocates of indigenous epistemology often argue that a distinct feature of Māori knowledge is genealogical transmission, which is phrased not in a historical but in a timeless fashion (see also Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo 2001:58). The distinction between insider and outsider that is implied in the central role of genealogies in the possession of indigenous knowledge, however, has been turned inside out through the hegemonization of Māori epistemology in the past. This has also been acknowledged by advocates of Māori epistemology such as Smith (2012 [1999]) who argue for the decolonization of indigenous knowledge. Knowledge about spirituality has been documented by outsiders and has to be converted again into inside knowledge, but in some cases insiders have great difficulties articulating the ins and outs of this body of knowledge. Indeed, in practice the boundaries between insider and outsider, subject and object, native and scholar are frequently dissolved so that Pacific communities may well be argued to find themselves “between knowledges” (Hviding 2003: 45) and, as a consequence, between different ontologies.

Still, some indigenous scholars increasingly think of indigenous peoples as having “inside knowledge” or even being “inside knowledge” (see Birdsall et al. 2009:3), which is a central consideration behind recent reflections on indigenous epistemology (e.g., Gegeo and Watson-Gegeo 2002; Roberts and Wills 1998; Smith 2012 [1999]; Tau 2001). The state of being inside may be considered a comfortable condition but at the same time might be regarded as a trap because it seems incompatible with other ways of knowing (Birdsall et al. 2009:3), consequently making it difficult for locals to speak from their hearts and, for example, to express a mundane concern about the depletion of fish. This dilemma also raises the question whether being inside knowledge is indeed a comprehensive frame forming subjectivity or whether indigenous actors are also active agents in the process of producing knowledge. Do we construct, reconstruct, or perhaps even make up knowledge? While the illusion of knowledge as objective and neutral appears to have been demystified in anthropology and the humanities and increasingly also in the natural sciences (Birdsall et al. 2009:2; see also Moore 1996; Mosko and Damon 2005), a crucial question remains unresolved: if not objective, then what?

From this discussion, it may be inferred that the relevance of philosophical debates about knowledge is limited since the questions raised above cannot simply be resolved in epistemology. In anthropology, knowing what is known and how people know is not just a theoretical problem but one that is inherently linked to ethnographic field research practices. And these are not infrequently embedded in politics, which compounds the problem. This angle makes the epistemological question of knowledge somewhat different in anthropology. In a recent reflection on this issue, Johannes Fabian (2012) varied on Geertz’s famous dictum “How you know you know” by

expressing the goal of his ethnographic work as follows: “We now ask (and should be able to answer) *what we know about how they know what they know*” (Fabian 2012:443; emphasis in original). This phrase seems at first sight rather similar to what Trevor Marchand (2010:Siv) considers to be the main business of anthropology, namely, “the making of knowledge about the ways other people make knowledge.” However, simply studying other people’s knowledge by acquiring and interpreting it does not immediately address the epistemological knowledge question in anthropology. After all, the case study in this paper demonstrates that a reflection on the object of the knowledge question in anthropology (Knowledge of what?) is incomplete without simultaneously addressing the question, Whose knowledge? (see Fabian 2012).

In his thoughtful reflection on these questions, Fabian (2012:444–445) made a distinction between knowledge as a state, a possession or knowledge as an activity or practice (see also Wood 2006). As a state, knowledge is opposed to ignorance, but the Māori were far from ignorant about the desecration of their lake, so this is not the type of knowledge that we are interested in. People in the community knew why the fish had been depleted in their lake, but they did not think they also had the knowledge to criticize the coal corporation. Knowledge was therefore not claimed as a possession either, although the debate about cultural property and intangible heritage has also been introduced in Māori politics (van Meijl 2009a). In the case study described in this paper, knowledge was above all an ongoing activity or a practice. This implies that neither scientific nor rhetorical criteria are sufficient to analyze the knowledge regarding the spiritual quality of the water. This is inherently linked to the anthropological enterprise of conducting ethnographic field research, involving semiosis, interpretation, analysis, and explanation, all requiring interaction and communication, which above all makes it pragmatic (Fabian 2012:447). For Fabian (2012:447) “pragmatic” also means that the kind of knowledge we seek “changes the knower” while at the same time “changing the known.” Neither anthropologists nor their interlocutors remain unaffected by ethnographic research. We may attempt to circumvent relations of power by strategic methodological accounts, ethical protocols, and critical reflection, but we cannot avoid that the construction of knowledge, or the reconstruction or coconstruction of knowledge, if you like, is essentially political in the practice of cultural anthropology. For that reason, too, it is important not only that we observe and participate with those whom we study but also that we confront each other openly when we present our findings, to reflect not only on the question of how anthropology comes to know but also how it can be sure of what it advances as knowledge (White and Strohm 2014). Indeed, as Fabian (2014:207) argued compellingly, anthropologists “must invoke intersubjectivity in their attempts to understand their practices of empirical knowledge production.”

This pragmatic viewpoint, which might be considered the trademark of contemporary anthropology, also constitutes the

angle from which I seek to explore two questions that emerge from the grammatical ambiguity of the phrase “to have inside knowledge” or “to be inside knowledge,” which characterizes indigenous discourses of epistemology: first, whether knowledge is an influential, all-encompassing frame determining indigenous lifeways and worldviews and, second, whether indigenous peoples are themselves active agents in the construction and deconstruction of different epistemic frameworks. The case study presented in this paper clearly suggests that knowledge is rarely an unequivocal construct or a representation of an unambiguous experience. This received conception of knowledge in the modern academy and uncritically integrated in the discourse of indigenous epistemology is to be replaced by a more dynamic view of knowledge as “knowing.” After all, knowledge cannot be separated from the process of its production. As a consequence, knowledge must never be considered as an accumulation of objective information, but instead it should be regarded as a never-ending process. Knowledge may also be constructed, interpreted, and experienced in a variety of different ways. As Birdsall and colleagues (2009:3) have argued, “All the active components of these processes may be better captured by the present participle ‘knowing’ than by the static noun ‘knowledge’.” If we think of humans accordingly as “doing” (or “undoing”) epistemology instead of “having” knowledge (Birdsall et al. 2009), both academic research and projects in indigenous epistemology only offer temporary insights, not permanent additions to a growing monolithic corpus of knowledge. Indeed, it is important to stress a plural conception of knowledge (Birdsall et al. 2009), which opens up the avenue to focus empirical inquiry on multiple practices of knowledge construction, production, and interpretation.

A plural conception of knowledge also draws attention to the fact that all knowledge is related to a number of different tropes. Indeed, we may even go further and depart from the argument that all language is metaphorical (Fernandez 1991; Lakoff and Johnson 1980). An important implication of this idea is that language only generates a shaky and ambiguous kind of knowledge, which is never founded on a stable, “literal” ground (Birdsall et al. 2009:5). Lakoff and Johnson (1980) explored the practical implications of this insight and demonstrated that metaphors are not just rhetorical devices. Instead, they argue that they are cognitive tools that model our thoughts and experiences and mold our everyday practices (see also Birdsall et al. 2009:5; Quinn 1991). This also clarifies why in the Māori community the link itself between spirituality and fish was never disputed, since the absence of eels clearly indicated the desecration of the water. The debate focused instead on the question whether the trope of spirituality was an effective or a mystifying rhetorical device to convey the concern of the community about the depletion of fish.

In the act of employing a trope, two different worldviews meet and displace each other with different meanings as something is said in terms of something else. Thus, tropes both connect and change the figurative and the literal, an animist ontology and a naturalist ontology, the self and the other, the

indigenous and the nonindigenous, the known and the not-yet-known (Birdsall et al. 2009:5). Due to their dialogical relations, they can mobilize meanings and engage encounters between different discourses, ontologies, and even ways of knowing (Birdsall et al. 2009). The cognitive, social, and also political function of tropes and their role in either reinforcing or destabilizing different ontological assemblages of knowledge and power has therefore not been overlooked by indigenous peoples. The *wairua* of the water, the lake and its *taniwha*, too, provide central metaphors for Māori connections to place. They enable them to articulate their resistance to European colonization, the confiscation of their lands, and the abuse of the environment (Strang 2010:7). Spirituality and images of the *taniwha* are therefore central themes in Māori discourses that present a critique of legal notions of property, of colonial misappropriation, and of economic practices that are evidently unsustainable. Indeed, the trope of the *wairua* and the *taniwha* challenges anthropology to develop a deeper understanding of the contribution that metaphors may make to alternative ways of knowing and of being.

Conclusion

Māori metaphors of water, spirituality, and fish and the multiple linkages between these entities that are both objective and subjective convey a conception of “knowing” that is contingent on situational factors. For that reason, too, I have argued that the received conception of knowledge has its limitations and that the phrase “ways of knowing” expresses more adequately that understanding depends on context and, accordingly, is characterized by plurality. Furthermore, in indigenous societies that are marked by a history of colonial relations, of dispossession and marginalization, knowing is also tied to ancestral rights to the environment, which corroborates the central argument of this paper. Māori ways of knowing are to be understood in light of the awareness that in indigenous worldviews the environment itself has a right of reply, which makes humans vulnerable to its rebuttals.

Interestingly, an explanation of the meaning of indigenous ways of knowing in the context of the case study discussed in this paper also draws attention to the tropes that are used to express a scientific conception of knowledge in Western academies. In a classic paper, Anne Salmond (1982:66) analyzed the epistemological metaphors that are used to discuss knowledge and truth in the West, which showed that scientific knowledge of ways of knowing is culturally inhibited, at least to some extent. Scientific discourses of knowledge, including discourses of knowledge in anthropology, routinely apply metaphors about location in a physical landscape, where the space-time coordination is considered a form of commonsense perception. Scientific metaphors of knowledge reflect a physical landscape, and knowing refers to physical activities on it. Thus, Anne Salmond (1982:67) demonstrated that the representation of knowledge as a landscape is linked with a series of related metaphors, including the view that intellectual activity

is a journey, that understanding is seeing, and that facts are natural objects. Understanding is essentially conceived of as a way of looking at things while traversing a landscape. It is grounded in a separation of the viewer and the viewed, of self and other, of subject and object, and as such it underlies all accounts of so-called objectivity. The view of facts and data as natural objects also follows from knowledge as a landscape and understanding as seeing. Facts are considered as objects, as hard, concrete, and tangible, as a consequence of which we talk about gathering data and doing fieldwork as though the essential features of other societies are lying on the landscape for our collection. Indeed, the epistemology of empiricism is deeply embedded in anthropological practices and requires constant reflection on its implications for our understandings of other ways of knowing.

The case study in this paper demonstrates compellingly that scientific metaphors of knowledge are unhelpful for understanding indigenous knowledge practices. Māori ways of knowing cannot simply be collected. They are unruly because they are linked to ancestral and environmental rights that are deeply intertwined with unequal power practices in a postcolonial setting. Māori understandings of the environment, of water, spirituality, and fish, cannot be unified objectively either, because there is no consensus in the community. For that reason, too, it is important to highlight the distinction between *mātauranga* and *mōhiotanga*, between knowledge as state and knowing as a process. Likewise, understanding is always subject of debate since it is also tied to situational factors. Two other Māori concepts corroborate the argument that indigenous ways of knowing are open, dynamic, and contested, namely, *kōrero* and *wānanga*. Their meaning in classic texts dating from the mid-nineteenth century has also been analyzed by Anne Salmond (1985). *Kōrero* is the form in which *mātauranga* or received knowledge was traditionally expressed, but never before it had been discussed extensively during *wānanga* or debating sessions held on ceremonial courtyards or *marae*. Both *kōrero* and *wānanga* reflect the open discussions held about the spiritual qualities of water and their relationships with fish in the Māori community discussed in this paper.

The debate about the interrelationships among water, spirituality, and fish in a Māori community also shows that indigenous ways of knowing do not easily fit within recent representations of indigenous epistemology. My review of Māori discussions about the epistemology of spirituality shows that in practice, indigenous conceptions of knowledge are more dynamic and open than some indigenous philosophers would like us to believe (see also Ballantyne 2011:240). The contrast between knowledge as a state and knowledge as an activity has been brought to light repeatedly in epistemological reflections on ethnographic research practices (Fabian 2012). As a consequence, it has also been suggested to abandon a quest for knowledge and focus research instead on understanding “ways of knowing” (Birdsall et al. 2009; Harris 2007). This proposition is suitable not only for ethnographic field research strategies in the discipline of anthropology but also for the dis-

course of indigenous epistemology so that its decolonization may become completed and a multiplicity of voices can speak openly.

Acknowledgments

Research for the ethnographic case study presented in this paper was conducted in the late 1980s, but, in consultation with the community, this material has not been published earlier (see n. 1). The theoretical analysis of the discussions within the Māori community has been developed only in recent years. I am very grateful to my mentor Taitimu Maipi and the late Te Ngaeroa Hetet and Tokoroa Waikato for inviting me to participate in their struggle for the environment around Lake Waahi. I also thank each and every one in the community at Waahi Pa for bearing with me over the years. Earlier versions of this paper have been presented at St. Andrews, Bergen, Nijmegen, Göttingen, Marseille, Hamilton, Auckland, and Wellington, and I am grateful to the audiences for their critical and constructive feedback. I also thank two anonymous reviewers for their comments and suggestions and for encouraging me to include a discussion of the “ontological turn.” Finally, I am indebted to a commentator for drawing my attention to some inadequacies. All remaining errors are, of course, my own.

Comments

Fiona McCormack

Anthropology Programme, University of Waikato, Te Whare
Wananga o Waikato, Private Bag 3105, Hamilton 3240,
New Zealand (fio@waikato.ac.nz). 26 VII 17

Toon van Meijl's essay is an insightful exploration of the politics and the internal and external dynamics of “doing indigenous epistemology.” Grounded in a provocative case study, Van Meijl questions the intellectual usefulness of dichotomizing indigenous and scientific perspectives on knowledge, but also insider and outsider knowledge, objectivist and subjectivist concepts of meaning, and animist and naturalist ontologies. Instead, he proffers a distinction between knowledge and ways of knowing, wherein the first refers to a definite understanding of something that is known and the second, ways of knowing as a strategy that includes both knowledge production and the interpretation of meaning. This categorization, he suggests, proffers a more flexible and dynamic approach to ethnographic analyses of indigenous knowledge making.

A central dynamic of the essay concerns the politics of indigeneity, though he does not refer to it in these terms. His ethnography recounts the precarity of indigenous claims to property and ownership within the colonial settler dynamics of New Zealand. He details the history of resource alienation and the struggle of Māori to maintain identity, recreational and livelihood practices, and human-environment relationships,

in the context of an extension of the environmental extractive activities of Coalcorp (a coal mining company and state-owned entity, privatized in 2015). It is a particularly poignant story involving the desecration of a culturally significant lake, Waahi, and the ecological condition of its source, the Waikato River.

Van Meijl traces the tensions, though also points of articulation, between the different epistemologies put forward by the Māori community and external experts as a means to counter the extension of water rights to Coalcorp. This bundle of knowledges includes categories that can be distinguished as indigenous insider, particularly those aspects relating to spirituality, and for this reason hint at ideological dimensions and factual daily-practice types of knowledge pertaining to the depletion of fish and the loss of recreational pursuits. Although these elements are entangled in Māori ways of knowing, such that eel numbers decreased because of polluted spiritual conditions, the esoteric knowledge needed to advance the ideological argument was largely held by outsiders, “because it no longer resonated with their ways of knowing and practicing spirituality in daily life.” Animist and naturalist ontologies clearly interact here, yet which achieves dominance is context specific. With regard to negating Coalcorp's application, the spiritual dimension was considered the most powerful as it had the advantage of sidelining technocratic expertise. This strategic mystification, however, is not so much an invention of tradition but rather an intricate component of the contemporary practice of indigeneity.

Taniwha have been successfully deployed by Māori as spiritual animators of resistance, for instance, in the case of Coalcorp as well as in the 2001 prevention of a prison facility in Ngawha. Māori submitted that the site was home to the *taniwha* Takauere and that the construction of the prison would impede its movement such that it would be “literally attacked by having mud thrown in its eyes.”⁵ In the recent Whanganui River settlement, *taniwha* also played a role. Indeed, New Zealand has received international accolades for its recognition of a Māori animist ontology, if you like, signified in the granting of legal personhood to the ancestral Whanganui River (Anne Salmond 2014). The Te Awa Tupua Act 2017 frames the river in relational terms, as “an indivisible and living whole, comprising the Whanganui River from the mountain to the sea, incorporating all its physical and metaphysical elements” (Pt 2/2 cl. 12, cl. 13b).

The engagement with a spiritual epistemology, however, does not appear to stifle neoliberal privatizations and may even provide a masquerade. While the Te Awa Tupua Act does not create property rights in the river, existing rights are excluded from its provisions, such as rights owned over hydroelectricity, commercial quota holdings over eel, existing public uses and resource consents, and the Crown's title to navigable rivers. The context in which the claims were negotiated included the imminent privatization of state-owned power companies,

5. *Taniwha* defeats prison project. *New Zealand Herald*, 2001. http://www.nzherald.co.nz/nz/news/article.cfm?c_id=1&objectid=177518.

an enclosure challenged nationally by Māori groups through an urgent hearing of the Waitangi Tribunal. The tribunal's findings at the time, including that Māori claims were "sufficient to require a halt to the sale" (Waitangi Tribunal 2012:234), led to a compromise, and a partial privatization proceeded. This concession was also, arguably, enacted in the granting of personhood to a river and in the anticipated acknowledgment of Māori rights and interests in freshwater—the latter of which, considering current freshwater privatization plans, is likely to result in the granting of property rights to tribal groups.

While spirituality may be a particularly novel way in which indigenous claims are recognized, older forms of colonial alienations are at play. A curious synergy occurs in repatriations whereby property becomes a point of equivalence making. In the case of the 1992 pan-Māori fisheries settlement, for instance, Māori commercial fishing rights were reconstructed as individual transferable quota (ITQ), whereas customary fishing became an aestheticized practice reserved for ritual occasions, an enactment of eco-indigeneity (McCormack 2011). In ITQ fisheries more wealth can be generated from trading property (quota) than chasing fish in the sea (McCormack 2017). For Māori quota holders this creates a double bind: the requirement to generate wealth from a treaty settlement while participating in a system that implicates massive shifts in how an environment is experienced, thought about, labored with, sustained, and genealogically interfused. Guardianship over a feature-full saltwater seascape is very different from guardianship over quota. The first implies reciprocal ecological behavior and the second, only responsible financial behavior.

Van Meijl's conceptualization of Māori "ways of knowing" as expressing an understanding of context, of process, and of plurality is a much-needed counter to the oft-impermeable classification of indigenous and Western epistemologies. It also has implications for ontologies. Such ways of knowing are dynamic; they entail human-environment relations and a worldview in which the environment has a right of reply. They are also produced as ancestral rights to the environment in a history marked by colonial dispossessions. *Taniwha* encapsulate this. In light of the privatization drive in New Zealand, however, and the inequality intrinsic to indigeneity, the path by which Māori ways of knowing are taken up by the powerful may have unintended, if not contrary, consequences.

Francesca Merlan

School of Archaeology and Anthropology, Australian National University, Canberra, Australian Capital Territory, Australia
(francesca.merlan@anu.edu.au). 15 VI 17

I find this paper valuable. However, I suggest repositioning its currently central thematization of knowledge and knowing. Toon van Meijl poses as an overarching question whether indigenous ways of knowing are all-encompassing ("cosmological") or (as in the Waahi Pa case he discusses) involve elements of "active agency" (meaning here, contextual selectivity,

strategic awareness). He asks this alongside more general consideration of knowledges and ways of knowing. It is commonly said that indigenous knowledge/s and scholarship differ from Western science and scholarship. Indigenous renaissance of cultural traditions and emphasis on indigenous knowledge/s are in train, he notes, as part of decolonizing moves. Recognizing the link between knowledge and power, indigenous people (from intellectual to ordinary) are concerned with the retrieval and control of knowledge/s. In this context, Van Meijl asks, What are indigenous knowledge frameworks? This brings him back to consideration of the difference between Western epistemologies (of varying kinds, the more "objectifying" and scientific versus the more interpretive and subjective), and a difference between "knowledge" as static and "knowing" as processual. Where do indigenous forms and claims of knowing stand, not only with respect to the forms of Western/indigenous divide but decolonizing attempts to regain control? Van Meijl alludes to the arguments of the so-called ontological turn, that there are differing realities. He does not support or fully pursue this line, arguing instead that, in his view, it is not productive to do so. Instead he avers that a stark dichotomy between scientific and indigenous knowledges is not useful, and indigenous knowing is neither singular nor static. Those conclusions, especially the last, seem acceptable to me; but it is worth examining the structure of argument more closely.

Van Meijl deploys the case of water quality at Waahi Pa to make the case that, in the recent revitalization of traditional knowledge, agency and not just all-encompassing cosmology is involved. Locals of Waahi Pa lake could see a clear decline in water quality and eel numbers since the installation of a coal plant. Both kinds of decline were of concern. However, they were not sufficiently compelling in Māori dealings with others to impose change on the coal project and prevent their returning recycled water to the lake. Anybody living long-term on a lake—not only Māori—might be inclined to link change in water quality with noticed decline in eel numbers. But one aspect of water quality that was distinctively Māori involved notions of water as "alive" and as *tapu*. Recycling of water might make it potable—and indeed one Māori, offered recycled water to test, found its quality good. But this could not be said to restore its taboo or "live" qualities.

These dimensions increasingly came to the fore, Van Meijl tells us, in community negotiations with the coal miners. They were not the principal concerns of most Māori initially: decline in eel numbers preoccupied them. When community people were given treated water to drink and found its quality good, their objections to the mine were in danger of having little impact. Arguments against the coal company on the basis of defiled sanctity of water were foregrounded by an educated spokesperson. This emphasis emerged as the only one of sufficient weight to make the coal company change its operations. Eventually, the company was ordered to construct a wetland on which to dump used water, not back into the lake.

This reveals an "insider story" of water quality—debates and differences among Māori concerning water and the adjacent coal plant. Not all Māori agree or share the same ontological

priorities. Van Meijl contends that stark difference between indigenous and Western knowing is shown to be implausible; indigenous knowing is open and dynamic to an extent many would not like to admit.

The case Van Meijl discusses reminds me of comparable others, for example, Australian “sacred sites” disputes in which, similarly, indigenous objection to mining may (sooner or later) come to pivot on what are argued to be spiritual values that mining may destroy, and that cannot be restored, no matter what the developers may say about regeneration. Here too, allegedly “spiritual” values are sometimes explicitly identified as the only ones that can override argument. However, I think the dynamic of the “insider stories” is inadequately framed by concepts of “knowledge.”

Indigenous people are made to consider novel, often dramatic, interventions and types of activity in familiar places and landscapes. This creates a dilemma: on what bases to react, how to evaluate this novelty in places they consider wrested from them in the first place? How does the intervention affect their relations to and understandings of places? What forces are deployed to mold their response? Van Meijl rightly mentions “unequal power practices in a postcolonial setting.” So why consider the issues here principally in terms of knowledge, knowing, and epistemological debates? What is the “more” to be said that creates a wider frame?

First, it seems to me that in colonial (and postcolonial) settings, indigenous ways of understanding and responding are, expectably, continually reconstituted—partly rather than entirely. Some Māori continue to feel and think in terms of *tapu*, while others may not. But second, colonized people become aware of the colonizing thinking and practices—again, to varying extents. Variably, they compare and contrast their own ways, reconstituted in the juncture, with those others. Like any good rhetorician, the experienced intellectual and negotiator Tama could discern that the *topoi* of sanctity and animate water quality would be weight-bearing, while more widespread concern about decline in eel numbers was likely to be counteracted by science-based arguments about water quality. Does this mean that understanding and feeling in terms of *tapu* has ceased to exist? Probably not. Does it mean that its existential positioning continues to shift in the power-knowledge-postcolonial interface Van Meijl has ably identified? Probably so. Finally, does Van Meijl mean to imply that Māori, when previously familiar with only their own ways of being, were cosmologically enclosed to the point of being nonagenitive? Forms of agency are also continually reconstituted.

Marama Muru-Lanning

James Henare Māori Research Centre, Building 225, 18 Wynyard Street, University of Auckland, Private Bag 92019, Auckland 1142, New Zealand (m.murulanning@auckland.ac.nz). 19 VII 17

When I was invited to remark on Van Meijl’s article I was uncertain of the perspective from which to write. Should I com-

ment as a Waikato insider who can *whakapapa* to the people and lands where the author conducts research, or an “objective” scholar of anthropology, or a researcher whose role is to conduct excellent research that advances Māori people? All three lenses are valuable to this discussion. I first read Van Meijl’s article in a hotel room in Munich as I was attending the biannual European Society for Oceanists meeting. In a twist of fate I found myself participating on a panel with him the next day. On meeting, I expressed the article was a seminal work and showed a deep commitment to ethnography. It also clearly demonstrated the binary relationship between knowledge and power and theorized the agency that actors have to make some knowledge(s) truth.

In my view, subject to two points, the article makes a sound contribution not only to anthropology but to Waikato Māori as well. First, he says that Waikato River waters are sourced from Mount Ruapehu. However, Waikato Māori say the river is sourced from Mount Tongariro to emphasize their relationship with Ngāti Tūwharetoa, an *iwi* at the southern end of the river. Second, I would have preferred he used the word *mauri*, meaning life force, to debate the metaphysical state of water rather than the term *wairua*, which for me means the spirit residing in human beings, not a spirit belonging to water, rivers, lakes, and wetlands. I went on to say that I could not be any more critical than that. Van Meijl’s response was “OK, but what does the article make you think of?” I responded, “Your article makes me think of Vision Mātauranga policy that all university researchers in New Zealand are now bound by.” Vision Mātauranga has been created to commodify and globalize Māori knowledge that belongs to Māori communities. Van Meijl encouraged me to comment on this.

In 2003, the Ministry of Research, Science and Technology started a program to refocus investment in Māori research. As part of the program, Charles Royal, a scholar educated at the Māori institution Te Wānanga o Raukawa, was commissioned to develop a framework that would “unlock the innovation potential of Māori knowledge, resources and people to assist New Zealanders to create a better future” (Ministry of Research, Science and Technology 2007). This framework is now known as Vision Mātauranga (hereafter, VM). According to Royal, VM is underpinned by the Māori concept of *mātauranga*, which is often translated as knowledge, wisdom, or ways of knowing. When Māori speak of knowledge, they commonly use the word *mātauranga*, though words such as *māramatanga* (to understand), *mōhiotanga* (to know), and *ākona* (to learn) also convey much of the same meaning.

In 2005 Royal’s VM framework was approved, and in 2010 the policy was integrated across all New Zealand investment priority areas (including the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment; the Royal Society; National Science Challenges; Centres of Research Excellence; and the Health Research Council) along with the establishment of a VM Capability Fund. While the policy concerns distinctive issues and opportunities arising within Māori communities, VM encourages research whose outcomes make contributions to New Zealand as a whole. Its four science research areas are (1) Indig-

enous Innovation: Contributing to economic growth; (2) Taiao-Environment: Achieving environmental sustainability through Māori relationships with land and sea; (3) Hauora-Health: Improving health and social well-being; and (4) Mātauranga: Exploring indigenous knowledge and science and innovation.

Drawing on my participation at many discussions about natural resources and meetings addressing the formation of a University of Auckland VM community of practice, I have considered the shifting power relationships and fluid boundaries of natural scientists who make intellectual claims to freshwater and other resources that Māori have interests and property rights in. With a focus on the shifting relationships between identity, knowledge, and power I ask, What opportunities and spaces for action does VM hold for anthropology?

In 2012, I wrote an article that critiqued VM by examining the relationships between Ngā Pae o te Māramatanga (National Centre of Māori Research Excellence), Ngāi Tahu Māori, and scientists with interests in freshwater (Muru-Lanning 2012). Having read Van Meijl's work, I now see that I barely scratched the surface regarding the multiple ways the policy is used as a mechanism to create and advance relationships between scientists and Māori. My article was somewhat cynical of the policy's design, which does not deal with the unequal power relationships created between science experts and flaxroot communities. My article noted the underlying extractive and co-optive nature of VM.

At the James Henare Māori Research Centre I am involved in projects representing the range of VM-associated research funding. Many of these projects are collaborations with non-Māori scholars from the sciences. Participation in multidisciplinary collaborations is where I see an opportunity for anthropology. What I have found when working with the new colleagues is they recognize the need to work with people who have disciplinary training in listening to what flaxroots people say. Our understanding of kinship, inequality, hierarchies, power, and other anthropological theory allows us to fill in cultural gaps for people that our science colleagues are not used to working with. Anthropologists may open up a world for the scientists that demonstrates that not all people think the same way as they do. What I am finding is that the collaborative work that our research center does with the scientists is complementary. VM policy done properly forces scholars to come together for long periods of planning where we listen to one another, participate in debates, and figure things out. I argue that in these situations we are actually doing participant observation. Thus I suggest that social anthropology go back to its roots, as Van Meijl advocates in his article, so we may develop alternate ways of thinking and acting. Penelope Harvey offers, "The powerful are those who have the ability to move things around" (2001:207). The relationship between location and movement involves the ability to create fixity and draw people into relationships with you, marking your place as central and defining the marginality of others. Instead of talking ourselves out of the game, we must carve out spaces where our disciplinary skills and training are desired and respected by our science colleagues.

Jeffrey Sissons

School of Social and Cultural Studies, Victoria University of Wellington, Kelburn Parade, PO Box 600, Wellington, New Zealand (jeff.sissons@vuw.ac.nz). 25 VI 17

Van Meijl is right to insist that epistemology must be about active, socially contested "ways of knowing" and that understanding the relationship between such ways and their products is as much an ethnographic problem as it is a philosophical one. Ways of knowing, as social practices, are also, more generally, ways of being or becoming and so are not, in my view, radically distinct from the ontologies they produce and reproduce. Philippe Descola (2013) argues strongly that his four "ontologies" are also schemas of practice, fundamental ways that people know, experience, and inhabit the world. I think Van Meijl is mistaken, therefore, when he characterizes the ontological turn in anthropology as being about different relations between mind and matter. For me, it is most significantly about the different ways that personhood or subjectivity can be understood and embodied.

Personhood, within Descola's "naturalist" ontology, can only be attributed to humans; attributions of personhood to nonhumans are always metaphorical and potentially mystifying. Van Meijl's understanding of Māori ways of knowing at Waahi Pa is, therefore, a wholly naturalist one in Descola's terms. It is founded on a sharp distinction between the ideological and the factual, the former expressed via metaphoric discourse and the latter by literal statements. As concepts within an ideological discourse or within an ideological way of knowing the world, *wairua* (spirit) and *taniwha* (ancestral embodiments) are said to have functioned as tropes or metaphors. When deployed externally, as they most often were in this Waahi case study, these tropes functioned politically. As concepts within a literal or factual way of knowing, "eels" referenced something real, and their numbers were the real, largely disguised concern of insiders.

My research in a Tuhoe community has led me to understand Māori ways of knowing about water, spiritual power, and ancestral embodiment very differently from Van Meijl. Indeed, while people switched between Descola's naturalist and animist ways of knowing, none of the elders from the community would normally have understood *wairua* and *taniwha* as tropes (just as a Scot would not normally understand "life" or the Loch Ness monster as tropes). The valley in which I conducted fieldwork takes its name from a sacred spring, Te Waimana (literally, water of *mana* or ancestral power), the water of which is said to have healed the wounds of a remote ancestor. I recorded several narratives about this spring, and in one account, told to me by Materoa, a woman in her 80s, it was spoken of as an ancestor. Materoa told me that the spring was *wairua*, spiritual water once used by an old couple to cover their sweet potato pit, thus concealing their harvest from some thieving spirits. One day, when Materoa was digging potatoes in a family garden she was overjoyed to see the spring emerge from the ground and flow toward her in what she understood to be an act of love (*aroaha*) toward its relative. Her companions

were not interested in such matters, however; they told her to get on with digging potatoes. The old woman told me that she never went back to this place because the experience of meeting with and separating from her kin was too painful for her and the water (Sissons 1993:110–113, 2013:390).

For Materoa, the Waimana spring was physically real, spiritually real, and ancestrally connected. For her companions, it was merely water. Contradicting Van Meijl's argument, neither Materoa nor her companions understood the spring to be symbolic or metaphoric in any way. The physical appearance of the spring initially delighted Materoa as much as the physical abundance of eels would have delighted the people of Waahi Pa. But for Materoa and, I suspect, for many of the Waahi people, such physical manifestations only served to confirm that spiritual agency and ancestral connection were equally real.

True, the people of Waimana have never needed to defend the purity of their spring from the direct aggression of a power company, but in 1880 they were forced to defend their land-rights in the Native Land Court of the colonial state. In the hearing to determine the ownership of the Waimana valley, the ability of kin groups to demonstrate ancestral connection to the spring was of central significance (Sissons 1993:87–113). While, in this context, the spring clearly took on new external political dimensions, it would not be helpful to sharply distinguish external or judicial ways of knowing and internal ways of knowing in this instance. For the judge the spring was water; for some of the claimants it was spirit. A naturalist distinction between an ideological trope and a literal presence would only confound our understanding of the complex relationships produced and reproduced by this court case, and I suggest this is also a risk for our understanding of the Waahi Pa case.

Despite my disagreement with Van Meijl's general argument concerning the ideological nature of some Māori ways of knowing, I think his ethnography poses a significant challenge to those who would draw strong boundaries around distinct ontological worlds. Materoa was a Mormon, and her children and grandchildren attended state schools where they were taught geography in English. Ways of knowing are indeed contextual and often antagonistic. Like Materoa, the people of Waahi Pa do not inhabit a distinct world; they share one world with all human and nonhuman persons, inhabiting it in different ways according to context. I thank Van Meijl for having so clearly identified and sensitively followed this shifting process ethnographically.

Reply

A deep bow and many thanks to my colleagues who took the time to comment on my analysis of a Māori struggle against the intrusion of a coal corporation on their natural environment and the related struggle with the question of how to ex-

press their anxiety and anger. Francesca Merlan questions the focus on knowledge and knowing in my study, but it must be considered foremost as a critical reflection on the emergence of a discourse of indigenous epistemology throughout the Pacific, especially in those countries that suffered most from the yoke of colonialism, such as Hawai'i and Aotearoa New Zealand.

Many scholars have commented on the essentialist construction of indigenous knowledge and epistemology in counter-colonial discourses, arguing that the implied dichotomy between Western and non-Western or indigenous knowledge usually correlates with the division between colonizers and colonized (e.g., Barnes 2006; Meiser 2017; Sillitoe 1998, including its comments and reply). Fundamental differences are frequently postulated, assuming homogeneity and stability on both sides of the division, whereas in practice complex forms of entanglement can hardly be denied. In this context, the construction of a dichotomy serves indigenous opposition against the hegemonic view that only Western science can stand up to academic scrutiny. Western science, however, is also rejected because it is indicative of a top-down approach that is imposed on indigenous lifeworlds, without recognition of the existence of Māori knowledge, especially in relation to the environment. Alternatively, *mātauranga Māori* is proposed as the indigenous corpus of knowledge originating from Māori ancestors who brought it to New Zealand from Polynesia and adapted it to their new milieu in Aotearoa but which became endangered in the course of colonization (e.g., Broughton and McBreen 2015; Hikuroa 2017).

In recent years, this type of knowledge has been acclaimed and criticized by both Māori and Pākehā alike. The Māori scholar Helen Moewaka Barnes (2006), for example, has argued that *mātauranga Māori* tends to lock Māori people in a time warp by insufficiently acknowledging the innovation that has taken place in Māori ways of knowing, thereby denying Māori ownership of types of knowledge that have become part of Māori society over the past 200 years. An upshot of this critique is that campaigns to recover indigenous epistemology from subalternity may alienate Māori forms of knowledge that include experiences of colonization, urbanization, and racism that are not considered interchangeable with traditional *mātauranga Māori*. My paper may therefore be read as an effort to make manifest the implications of intellectual constructions of indigenous knowledge for nonintellectuals who find themselves trapped in expectations of embodying a traditional worldview that are increasingly difficult to meet (see also Van Meijl 2006).

Marama Muru-Lanning draws attention in her comment to the recent institutionalization of *Mātauranga Māori* (with a capital M) in New Zealand academia since the introduction of the so-called Vision *Mātauranga* by the Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment (2015). This new policy seeks to unlock "the science and innovation potential of Māori knowledge, resources and people . . . for the benefit of New Zealand" (www.mbie.govt.nz). Since the rigorous neoliberalization of

the New Zealand economy in the mid-1980s, this move can be considered as yet a further extension of the capitalist frontier by commodifying and globalizing Māori knowledge. The neocolonial appropriation of Māori knowledge is acknowledged by Muru-Lanning, but in spite of her cynicism about the co-optative character of Vision Mātauranga, she has no illusions about the opportunity to reverse the tendency toward neoliberalizing Māori knowledge. As a consequence, she counts her blessings and elects strategically to collaborate in multidisciplinary research projects to ensure that Māori communities are consulted. As such, she acts as an important mediator between indigenous people at the flaxroots and Pākehā scientists. Her dual identity as Māori anthropologist enhances her contribution to bring alternative ways of thinking and doing to the attention of scientists and policy makers. Indeed, her work is invaluable, both to secure Māori interests and to transform unidimensional types of thinking in the sciences and within the New Zealand government.

The comments by Muru-Lanning confirm that the debate about unequal power relations in New Zealand is since the rise of the discourse of indigenous epistemology partly about different conceptions and conceptualizations of knowledge. This is likely to be different in Australia, from which setting Merlan provides her comments. Her qualms about the dynamics of “insider stories” as depicted in my paper are based on experiences in Aboriginal communities that have lived in relative isolation in the Australian outback until relatively recently, whereas Māori have been immersed in a colonial society for approximately 200 years. I hasten to add, however, that this does not at all imply that beliefs in *tapu* conditions have ceased to exist (see also below). At the same time, it would be silly to think that Māori engrossed in an animist ontology would lack any form of agency. This suggestion can proceed only from a dichotomous perspective that I have rejected explicitly from the outset.

For that reason, too, I cannot but take issue with Jeffrey Sissons’s reading of my analysis as founded on a sharp distinction between an animist and a naturalist ontology. Instead, I argue that both are intertwined, and the very tension produced by their uneasy relationship is the subject of my research, which ironically is appreciated by Fiona McCormack. I do make an analytical distinction between an ideological and a factual dimension of the argument made by the Māori community, but this has not inhibited me from being very candid about the absence of a rigid rupture between an animist and a naturalist ontology, and, accordingly, between the ideological and the factual dimension of the community’s objections against Coalcorp’s application for a renewal of water rights. I was hoping not to run the risk of such an interpretation and therefore argued explicitly that my argument was “not that the spiritual quality of the water was insignificant” since there was no disagreement in the community about the link between the transgression of spirituality and the depletion of fish.

In this context, there is also a misunderstanding about my use of the concept of metaphor. Sissons indicates that I sug-

gest that metaphors are unreal, but since the publication of *Metaphors We Live By*, by Lakoff and Johnson (1980), I was assuming that we were past the argument that a metaphor simply refers to something that it isn’t. Instead, “the essence of metaphor is understanding *and experiencing* one kind of thing in terms of another” (Lakoff and Johnson 1980:5; emphasis added). From this it may be inferred that Sissons and I are not at all in disagreement since I concur that a metaphor and its referent are equally real. Hence I had no hesitation either to contend that nobody (*sic*) disputed that the desecration of the water explained the pollution of the lake and the depletion of fish. The main point I attempted to make, however, concerned Māori uncertainty about the efficacy of their multistranded argument in view of Pākehā expectations of Māori epistemology that is generally framed in spiritual terms as a timeless tradition. After all, Māori were angry not only about the transgression of the spirituality of the water in the lake and its waterways but, above all, about the lack of recognition of their indigeneity, the confiscations of their land in the nineteenth century, and the complete absence of control of their natural surroundings which they considered as their “own.”

Not surprisingly, the coexistence of an animist and a naturalist ontology around Lake Waahi is strikingly similar to the ethnographic situation among the Tuhoe as described by Sissons. Even though he conducted research in a rural and more isolated region, he shows that Tuhoe society was also characterized by a combination of animism and naturalism to the extent that the supernatural experiences of his key informant Materoa were not acknowledged by her companions, who apparently did not share her subjectivity. For Materoa, the Waimana spring provided a spiritual connection to her ancestors, but for her companions it was simply water. Unfortunately, Sissons does not elaborate on the implications of these different experiences among his interlocutors, although he does argue that the ancestral connection of the spring was equally real for all. Still, he prioritizes Materoa’s narrative above the experiences of her companions in his alternative reading of my argument, whereas I aimed at addressing the internal debate about the obvious differences within one community. And given the widespread diversity within contemporary Māori society, I would argue that it is essential to do so.

McCormack eloquently points out the necessity to analyze internal debates about indigenous knowledge and the contextual articulation of animist and naturalist ontologies. In view of the precarity of Māori claims to regain ownership of the natural resources of which they were dispossessed in the course of colonial history, she astutely remarks that the increasing acknowledgement of the spiritual significance of Māori resources may disguise an ongoing process of alienation. Rivers may be granted the status of ancestor in New Zealand, in which case questions of ownership may be avoided to recognize legal forms of personhood, but this acknowledgment of the spiritual significance of natural resources does not necessarily stop the process of colonial dispossession in a wider sense. McCormack

offers the tragic example of the Māori fisheries settlement, returning to Māori ownership a wealth of individual transferable quota (ITQ), but still very few Māori fishermen are back in business since the exploitation of the quota has been outsourced to commercial companies that are not employing many Māori. The same could be argued about Lake Waahi: the spiritual significance of the water has been acknowledged, but measures to ensure the return of fish have not been introduced. And, sadly, this also applies to the national process of settling Māori ownership claims. Many Māori tribes may have become wealthy corporations with an astronomical asset base, but it is questionable to what extent this contributes to alleviating Māori poverty. My analysis of the struggle in a Māori community to formulate the right type of argument to counter colonial alienation demonstrates that the essentialization of Māori knowledge in the discourse of indigenous epistemology is not necessarily advantageous for that purpose.

—Toon van Meijl

References Cited

- Alberti, Benjamin. 2016. Archaeologies of ontology. *Annual Review of Anthropology* 45:163–179.
- Appadurai, Arjun. 1995. The production of locality. In *Counterworks: managing the diversity of knowledge*. R. Fardon, ed. Pp. 204–225. London: Routledge.
- Babadzan, Alain. 2009. *Le spectacle de la culture: globalisation en traditionalismes en Océanie*. Paris: L'Harmattan.
- Ballantyne, Tony. 2011. Paper, pen, and print: the transformation of the Kai Tahu knowledge order. *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 53 (2):232–260.
- Barnes, Helen Moewaka. 2006. Transforming science: how our structures limit innovation. *Social Policy Journal of New Zealand* 29:1–16.
- Birdsall, Carolyn, Maria Boletsi, Itay Sapir, and Pieter Verstraete, eds. 2009. *Inside knowledge: (un)doing ways of knowing in the humanities*. Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars.
- Broughton, D., and K. McBreen. 2015. Mātauranga Māori, Tino Rangatiratanga and the future of New Zealand science. *Journal of the Royal Society of New Zealand* 45(2):83–88.
- Brown, Michael F. 2003. *Who owns native culture?* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Descola, Philippe. 2013. *Beyond nature and culture*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Fabian, Johannes. 2012. Cultural anthropology and the question of knowledge. *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 18(2):439–453.
- . 2014. Ethnography and intersubjectivity: loose ends. *Hau: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 4(1):199–209.
- Fernandez, James W., ed. 1991. *Beyond metaphor: the theory of tropes in anthropology*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
- Friedman, Jonathan, and Kajsa Ekholm Friedman. 2013. Globalization as a discourse of hegemonic crisis: a global systemic analysis. *American Ethnologist* 40(2):244–257.
- Gegeo, David Welchman. 2001. (Re)visioning knowledge transformation in the Pacific. *Contemporary Pacific* 13(1):178–183.
- Gegeo, David Welchman, and Karen Ann Watson-Gegeo. 2001. “How we know”: Kwara'ae rural villagers doing Indigenous epistemology. *Contemporary Pacific* 13(1):55–88.
- . 2002. Whose knowledge? epistemological collisions in Solomon Islands community development. *Contemporary Pacific* 14(2):377–409.
- Gillett, Grant. 2009. Indigenous knowledges: circumspection, metaphysics, and scientific ontologies. *Sites: A Journal of Social Anthropology and Cultural Studies* 6(1):97–115.
- Harmsworth, Garth, Shaun Awatere, and Mahuru Robb. 2016. Indigenous Māori values and perspectives to inform freshwater management in Aotearoa-New Zealand. *Ecology and Society* 21(4):9.
- Harris, Mark, ed. 2007. *Ways of knowing: new approaches in the anthropology of experience and learning*. New York: Berghahn.
- Harvey, Penelope. 2001. Landscape and commerce: creating contexts for the exercise of power. In *Contested landscapes: movement, exile and place*. B. Bender and M. Winer, eds. Pp. 197–210. Oxford: Berg. [MM-L]
- Hau'ofa, Epeli. 1993. Our sea of islands. In *A new Oceania: rediscovering our sea of islands*. Eric Waddell, Vijay Naidu, and Epeli Hau'ofa, eds. Pp. 2–16. Suva: University of the South Pacific, School of Social and Economic Development/Breake House.
- . 2000. Pasts to remember. In *Remembrance of Pacific pasts: an invitation to remake history*. R. Borofsky, ed. Pp. 453–471. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press.
- Hereniko, Vilsoni. 2000. Indigenous knowledge and academic imperialism. In *Remembrance of Pacific pasts*. R. Borofsky, ed. Pp. 78–91. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press.
- Hermann, Elfriede, ed. 2011. *Changing contexts—shifting meanings: transformations of cultural traditions in Oceania*. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press.
- Hikuroa, D. 2017. Mātauranga Māori—the Ūkaipō of knowledge in New Zealand. *Journal of the Royal Society of New Zealand* 47(1):5–10.
- Huffer, Elise, and Ropato Qalo. 2004. Have we been thinking upside-down? the contemporary emergence of Pacific theoretical thought. *Contemporary Pacific* 16(1):87–116.
- Hviding, Edvard. 2003. Between knowledges: Pacific studies and academic disciplines. *Contemporary Pacific* 15(1):43–73.
- Hviding, Edvard, and Knut M. Rio, eds. 2011. *Made in Oceania: social movements, cultural heritage and the state in the Pacific*. Wantage, UK: Sean Kingston.
- Keck, Verena, ed. 1998. *Common worlds and single lives: constituting knowledge in Pacific societies*. Oxford: Berg.
- Kohn, Eduardo. 2013. *How forests think: toward an anthropology beyond the human*. Berkeley: University of California Press.
- . 2015. Anthropology of ontologies. *Annual Review of Anthropology* 44:311–327.
- Lakoff, George, and Mark Johnson. 1980. *Metaphors we live by*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Lechte, John. 2003. *Key contemporary concepts: from abjection to Zeno's paradox*. London: Sage.
- Māhina, Hūfanga 'Okusitino. 2010. Tā, Vā, and Moana: temporality, spatiality, and indigeneity. *Pacific Studies* 33(2/3):168–202.
- Mahuika, Apirana. 1998. Whakapapa is the heart. In *Living relationships: Kokiri Ngatahi; the treaty of Waitangi in the new millennium*. K. S. Coates and P. G. McHugh, eds. Pp. 214–221. Wellington: Victoria University Press.
- Marchand, Trevor H. J. 2010. Preface. *Making knowledge*. Special issue, *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* S1:Siii–Sv.
- McCan, David. 2001. *Whatiwhatihoe: the Waikato Raupatu claim*. Wellington: Huia.
- McCormack, F. 2011. Levels of indigeneity: the Maori and neoliberalism. *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 17(2):281–300. [FM]
- . 2017. Sustainability in New Zealand's quota management system: a convenient story. *Marine Policy* 80:35–46. [FM]
- Meiser, Anne. 2017. Alternative models of knowledge as a critique of epistemic power structures—introduction. *Sociologus* 67(1):1–22.
- Merlan, Francesca. 2009. Indigeneity: global and local. *Current Anthropology* 50(3):303–333.
- Metge, Joan. 1976 (1967). *Rautahi: the Maoris of New Zealand*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.
- Meyer, Manulani Aluli. 2001. Our own liberations: reflections on Hawaiian epistemology. *Contemporary Pacific* 13(1):124–148.
- . 2003. *Ho'oulu: our time of becoming: collected early writings of Manulani Aluli Meyer*. Honolulu: 'Ai Pōhaku.
- Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment. 2015. *National statement of science investment: 2015–2025*. Wellington: Ministry of Business, Innovation and Employment. [MM-L]
- Ministry of Research, Science and Technology. 2007. *Vision Mātauranga: unlocking the innovation potential of Māori knowledge, resources and people*. Wellington: Ministry of Research, Science and Technology. [MM-L]
- Moore, Henrietta L. 1996. The changing nature of anthropological knowledge: an introduction. In *The future of anthropological knowledge*. H. L. Moore, ed. Pp. 1–15. London: Routledge.
- Mosko, Mark S., and Frederick H. Damon, eds. 2005. *On the order of chaos: social anthropology and the science of chaos*. New York: Berghahn.
- Muru-Lanning, Marama. 2012. Maori research collaborations, Mātauranga Māori science and the appropriation of water in New Zealand. *Anthropological Forum: A Journal of Social Anthropology and Comparative Sociology* 22(2):151–164. [MM-L]

- Paleček, Martin, and Mark Risjord. 2013. Relativism and the ontological turn within anthropology. *Philosophy of the Social Sciences* 43(1):3–23.
- Quinn, Naomi. 1991. The cultural basis of metaphor. In *Beyond metaphor: the theory of tropes in anthropology*. J. F. Fernandez, ed. Pp. 56–93. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
- Roberts, Mere. 2012. Mind maps of the Māori. *GeoJournal* 77:741–751.
- . 2013. Ways of seeing: Whakapapa. *Sites: A Journal of Social Anthropology and Cultural Studies* 10(1):93–120.
- Roberts, Mere, Brad Haami, Richard Benton, Terre Satterfield, Melissa L. Finucane, Mark Henare, and Manuka Henare. 2004. Whakapapa as a Māori mental construct: some implications for the debate over genetic modification of organisms. *Contemporary Pacific* 16(1):1–28.
- Roberts, Roma Mere, and Peter R. Wills. 1998. Understanding Maori epistemology: a scientific perspective. In *Tribal epistemologies: essays in the philosophy of anthropology*. H. Wautischer, ed. Pp. 43–77. Aldershot: Ashgate.
- Salmond, Amiria J. M. 2013. Transforming translations. 1. The owner of the bones. *Hau: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 3(3):1–31.
- . 2014. Transforming translations. 2. Addressing ontological alterity. *Hau: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 4(1):155–187.
- Salmond, Anne. 1975. *Hui: a study of Maori ceremonial gatherings*. Wellington: Reed.
- . 1982. Theoretical landscapes: on cross-cultural conceptions of knowledge. In *Semantic anthropology*. D. Parkin, ed. Pp. 65–87. London: Academic Press.
- . 1985. Maori epistemologies. In *Reason and morality*. J. Overing, ed. Pp. 240–263. London: Tavistock.
- . 2014. Tears of Rangī: water, power, and people in New Zealand. *Hau: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 4(3):285–309. [FM]
- Sillitoe, Paul. 1998. The development of Indigenous knowledge: a new applied anthropology. *Current Anthropology* 39(2):223–252.
- Sissons, J. 1993. *Te Waimana, the Spring of Mana: Tuhoe history and the colonial encounter*. Dunedin: Otago University Press. [JS]
- . 2013. Reterritorialising kinship: the Maori Hapu. *Journal of the Polynesian Society* 122(4):373–392. [JS]
- Smith, Linda Tuhiwai. 2012 (1999). *Decolonizing methodologies: research and Indigenous peoples*. London: Zed.
- Strang, Veronica. 2010. The summoning of dragons: ancestral spirits and Indigenous water rights in Australia and New Zealand. *Anthropology News* 51(2):5–7.
- Subramani. 2001. The oceanic imagery. *Contemporary Pacific* 13(1):149–162.
- . 2003. Emerging epistemologies. Paper presented at a conference about South Pacific literatures, Noumea, New Caledonia, October 2003.
- Tau, Te Maire. 2001. Mātauranga Māori as epistemology. In *Histories, power and loss: uses of the past—a New Zealand commentary*. A. Sharp and P. McHugh, eds. Pp. 61–73. Wellington: Bridget Williams.
- van Meijl, Toon. 1993. The Maori King Movement: unity and diversity in past and present. *Bijdragen tot de taal-, land- en volkenkunde* 149(4):673–689.
- . 1996. Community development among the New Zealand Maori: the Tainui case. In *Indigenous organizations and development*. Peter Blunt and D. Michael Warren, eds. Pp. 193–213. Studies in Indigenous Knowledge and Development. London: Intermediate Technology.
- . 2003. Conflicts of redistribution in contemporary Maori society: leadership and the Tainui settlement. *Journal of the Polynesian Society* 112:260–279.
- . 2006. Multiple identifications and the dialogical self: Maori youngsters and the cultural renaissance. *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 12(4):917–933.
- . 2009a. Māori intellectual property rights and the formation of ethnic boundaries. In *Pacific discourses about cultural heritage and its protection*. Toon van Meijl, ed. Special issue, *International Journal of Cultural Property* 16(3):341–355.
- . 2009b. *Pacific discourses about cultural heritage and its protection*. Special issue, *International Journal of Cultural Property* 16(3):221–232.
- . 2013. Ownership and distribution in the settlement of Maori grievances: balancing historical and social justice between classes. In *Engaging with capitalism: cases from Oceania*. Kate Barclay and Fiona McCormack, eds. Pp. 29–52. Research in Economic Anthropology, vol. 33. Bingley: Emerald.
- Viveiros de Castro, Eduardo. 2012. *Cosmological perspectivism in Amazonia and elsewhere: four lectures given in the Department of Social Anthropology, Cambridge University, February–March 1998*. Hau Masterclass Series, vol. 1. Manchester.
- Waitangi Tribunal. 2012. *National freshwater and geothermal resource claim, Wai 2358*. Wellington: Waitangi Tribunal. [FM]
- White, Bob W., and Kiven Stroh. 2014. Ethnographic knowledge and the aporias of intersubjectivity. *Hau: Journal of Ethnographic Theory* 4(1):189–197.
- Wood, Houston. 2006. Three competing research perspectives for Oceania. *Contemporary Pacific* 18(1):33–55.